Backroundo

Installation & Setup

Version 1.4 · for macOS 13 (Ventura) or later

Backroundo changes your Mac wallpaper automatically – with photos from Unsplash, Pexels and Pixabay, the best pictures from Wikimedia Commons, paintings from the Metropolitan Museum or your own photo folder. The app sits quietly in the menu bar, shows a preview of the current image, remembers favorites and fades smoothly from the old image to the new one. It speaks English or German, depending on your Mac's language.

1. Requirements

System	macOS 13 Ventura or later
Mac	Apple silicon (M1, M2, M3 …) or Intel
Internet	for all online image sources
Account	not needed – only Unsplash, Pexels and Pixabay each require a free key (section 3)

2. Installation

1. Double-click **Backroundo-1.4.dmg**. A window opens.
2. Drag **Backroundo** onto the **Applications** folder.
3. Close the window and eject the “Backroundo” drive in Finder.
4. Open **Applications** and double-click **Backroundo**.

First launch: “Backroundo can’t be opened”

Backroundo is not registered with Apple as a developer app (that costs a yearly fee), so macOS blocks it the first time. Here is how to open it anyway – you only need to do this once:

1. Click **Done** in the message.
2. Open **System Settings → Privacy & Security** and scroll down.
3. Next to “Backroundo was blocked …” click **Open Anyway** and enter your password.
4. Choose **Open** in the next prompt.

Alternatively, enter this once in the **Terminal** app:

```
xattr -dr com.apple.quarantine /Applications/Backroundo.app
```

Once running, the Backroundo icon (a small picture) appears at the top right of the menu bar. The app intentionally does not show up in the Dock. Settings open automatically on first launch.

3. Choosing image sources

In Settings under **Image Sources**, tick where your images should come from. With several sources, Backroundo picks one at random each time. **Wikimedia** is already switched on, so Backroundo works right away without any account.

Unsplash	high-quality photos by search term or category · needs your own free key (see A)
Pexels	more professional photos in full resolution, same search term · needs your own free key (see B)
Pixabay	large collection of free photos, same search term · needs your own free key (see C)
Wikimedia	“Picture of the Day” from Wikimedia Commons – hand-picked photos, freely licensed · no key
Art	public-domain paintings from the Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York (landscapes, sea …) · no key
My favorites	the images you saved with ♥ – on their own or mixed with other sources
Your own folder	your own photos (see D)

As soon as Unsplash, Pexels or Pixabay is ticked, the **Search** section appears. The search term and category apply to all three – English terms work best, e.g. “mountains”.

A) Getting an Unsplash key – free, about 3 minutes

1. Create a free account at **unsplash.com/join** (or sign in).
2. Open **unsplash.com/oauth/applications** and click **New Application**.
3. Tick all the API terms checkboxes and click **Accept terms**.
4. Enter a name such as “Backroundo personal” and a description such as “Wallpapers for my Mac”, then click **Create application**.
5. On the next page, scroll down to **Keys** and copy the **Access Key** – not the Secret Key.
6. In Backroundo: click **Settings → Unsplash → Access Key** and paste it with ⌘**V**.
7. Under **Search**, tap a category or enter a search term and click **New Wallpaper Now**.

B) Getting a Pexels key – free, about 2 minutes

1. Create a free account at **pexels.com** (or sign in).
2. Open **pexels.com/api** and request an API key. In the short form enter e.g. “Backroundo personal” and “Wallpapers for my Mac” as the purpose.
3. The key is shown right away – copy it.
4. In Backroundo: tick **Pexels**, then click **Settings → Pexels → Access Key** and paste it with ⌘**V**.

Note: Pexels is not issuing new keys right now

Pexels has temporarily paused issuing new API keys (as of October 2026). If you already have a key, you can keep using it. Everyone else can use Unsplash or Pixabay for now – once Pexels issues keys again, the steps above will work.

C) Getting a Pixabay key – free, about 1 minute

1. Create a free account at **pixabay.com** (or sign in).
2. Open **pixabay.com/api/docs** – while signed in, your personal key is shown right on the page (section **Parameters**, row **key**). Copy it.
3. In Backroundo: tick **Pixabay**, then click **Settings → Pixabay → Access Key** and paste it with ⌘**V**.

Good to know

Limits: a new Unsplash key allows 50 requests per hour, Pexels 200 per hour, Pixabay 100 per minute – plenty for automatic changes.
Pixabay image size: with a standard key Pixabay delivers images at most 1280 pixels wide, which can look a little soft on large or Retina displays. If Pixabay grants you extended access (“Full API Access”), Backroundo automatically uses full resolution.
Keys are personal: please don’t share them. Every user needs their own. The provider’s terms of use apply to your key, and the key holder is responsible for following them. The photos belong to their photographers – Backroundo shows their name in the preview.

D) Your own folder

Tick **Your own folder**, click **Choose…** and select a folder of photos. Subfolders are included. Supported formats are JPG, PNG, HEIC, WebP, TIFF, GIF and BMP. If macOS asks for access to the folder, click **Allow**.

4. Using Backroundo

Click the menu bar icon to open the Backroundo window:

Preview	shows the current image with author and source; click it to open the image page in your browser
Next Wallpaper	loads a new wallpaper right away
♥ Heart	saves the image to your favorites (click again to remove it)
Favorites	opens your favorites library (icon with four squares)
Categories	Nature, Mountains, Ocean, Night, City … – loads a matching image from Unsplash, Pexels or Pixabay (key needed)
Change automatically	Off, every 15/30 min, every 1/3/12 h or daily
Settings	image sources, search, keys, folder and more options

More options in Settings

Multiple displays	the same image everywhere or a different image on each display
Smooth transition	soft cross-fade when the image changes (on/off)
Show splash screen	short animation when the app starts (click to skip)
Open at login	Backroundo starts automatically with your Mac

Favorites library

Every image you saved with the heart appears as a tile in the library – newest first, with author and source. **Click** a tile to set it as your wallpaper. **Right-click** to open the image page, show it in Finder or remove it from your favorites.

> **Note on multiple desktops (Spaces)**
> macOS only changes the image on the desktop that is currently visible. Other desktops keep their previous image.

5. Where are the images?

Favorites	~/Pictures/Backroundo/Favoriten
Cache	~/Pictures/Backroundo/Cache – cleaned up automatically

6. Troubleshooting

Error messages start with the name of the source, e.g. “Pexels: Invalid key”.

“Invalid key”	Copy the key again and check for spaces at the start or end. For Unsplash, use the Access Key, not the Secret Key.
“Limit reached”	The provider’s requests are used up (see “Good to know”) – wait a little or add another source.
“No images found”	Try a different search term.
“No suitable image”	The source had no landscape image just now – simply click **Next Wallpaper** again.
Pixabay images look soft	With a standard key Pixabay delivers at most 1280 pixels – prefer Unsplash or Pexels, or apply for extended access at Pixabay.
Icon missing from the menu bar	On MacBooks with a notch the menu bar may be full – hide other icons or restart Backroundo from Applications.
Open at login doesn’t work	Backroundo must be in the Applications folder. Check under System Settings → General → Login Items.

7. Uninstalling

1. Turn off **Open at login** in Settings.
2. Quit Backroundo (menu bar icon → **Quit**).
3. Drag **Backroundo** from Applications to the Trash.
4. Optional: delete the folder **~/Pictures/Backroundo** and remove the settings in Terminal:

```
defaults delete de.marcoschulz.backroundo
```

8. License & contact

Backroundo is **freeware**: free to use and to pass on unchanged, complete and free of charge. Selling or modifying it is not allowed. The full terms, liability and privacy notes are in **License.txt** (English translation) and **Lizenz.txt** (legally binding German version).

Backroundo collects no data and contains no ads or tracking.

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